Middle East Weekly Review

October 5 to October 11, 2026

- **Week in brief:** The Houthi and Saudi war overtook Hormuz as the week's driver, with repeated Houthi strikes on Riyadh's King Khalid airport, airline suspensions, a Yemeni ground offensive on the Red Sea coast and, by Saturday, Trump saying the US "may" join Saudi strikes on the Houthis, while his pledge of no strikes on Iran before the November 3 midterms held and Iran said it had revised its proposals; Brent ended the week near $104.7, up about 2%, and KOSPI fell about 5% in three sessions despite Samsung's record quarter.

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1. The Week's Arc

The week began with Brent at $100.32 on October 5 after Aramco's Asia price cut and a recovery in Gulf exports, and with the Yemeni government launching a ground and naval offensive on the Red Sea coast (confirmed October 6). Houthi claims on Riyadh and Rabigh followed, and Saudi authorities confirmed attacks on Jizan and Najran airports. The contest over Mokha and the Bab el-Mandeb coast stayed disputed all week, each side claiming control.

Hormuz tanker attacks set records on October 8 (UKMTO counted nine in the first six days of October), and Brent spiked about 5% intraday toward $105 alongside Gulf shut-ins from Hurricane Isaias. Trump then posted that the US will not attack Iran before November 3 and Pezeshkian said Iran had revised its proposals, while the NYT reported a drafted three day US strike campaign that Trump has not approved. The structural change is the pairing of a restraint pledge with open planning for the period after the election.

The war's centre of gravity moved to Riyadh. Houthi attacks on King Khalid airport on October 8 and again on October 10 killed civilians (counts conflict), closed the airport, and led Lufthansa, Emirates, Etihad and others to suspend flights, with 324 cancellations on October 10. On Saturday Trump said the US may join the Saudi campaign against the Houthis. Russia's promise of 300,000 tonnes of diesel, a Treasury waiver and a German 15 million barrel release answered the price level, not the war, and the Kremlin said Putin relayed Iran's views to Trump.

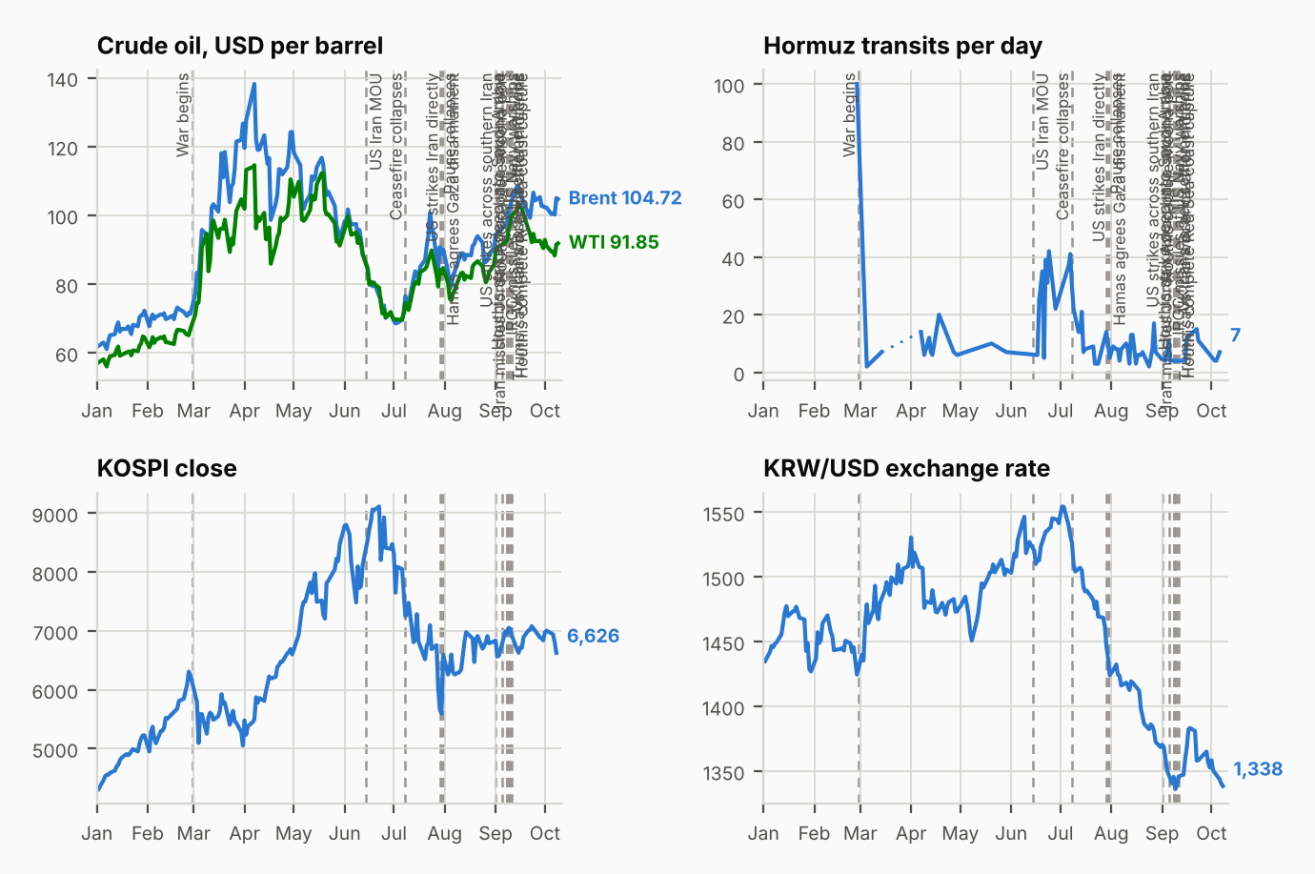
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2. Indicator Scoreboard

Thirteen new indicators were opened from October 5 to October 11 (IND-20261005-1 through IND-20261011-3). Resolved this week: **Confirmed** IND-20261003-1 (Yemeni offensive, October 6), IND-20260929-1 and IND-20261001-1 (Iran's disclosed revised proposals) and IND-20261006-1 (Saudi confirmation of attacks at King Khalid airport, today); **Falsified** IND-20261001-2 (no foreign net buying week), IND-20261002-1 (flydubai attribution), IND-20261002-2 (no attribution of the Oman supertanker strike), IND-20260930-1 (no disclosed US sequencing reply) and IND-20261004-1 (no confirmation of the Aramco strike south of Riyadh, today); **Expired** IND-20260918-1. The ledger holds 237 indicators, with 55 still marked Open, a number of them well past their stated deadlines awaiting a clean up.

Calibration note: Claims of Houthi hits on Saudi oil sites keep falling on the confirmation test (Aramco south of Riyadh, Khurais), while the aviation hits were confirmed quickly by Saudi authorities, which suggests the Houthis' verifiable damage is concentrated on airports. Market indicators remain driven by the chip cycle and foreign flows more than by the war.

3. Data Trends



Brent settled at $100.32 (Oct 5), $100.58 (Oct 6), $100.20 (Oct 7), then about $105 intraday on Oct 8 and about $104.7 on Oct 9, a weekly gain of about 2% over $102.25 on Oct 2. WTI ended at $91.85, with the spread to Brent near $13. KOSPI closed at 6,941.39 (Oct 6), 6,803.90 (Oct 7) and 6,625.93 (Oct 8), about 5.4% below its October 2 close of 7,003.74, on foreign net selling of 3.11 trillion won on Oct 7 and 1.99 trillion won on Oct 8, even with Samsung's record third quarter preliminary profit; the won held near 1,338 to 1,344 per dollar. Hormuz tanker transits were thin (7 on Oct 6, lowest since July 23), and no later count was found.

4. Slow Threads

- **Qatar's Ras Laffan LNG loadings (IND-20260714-4):** still no fresh weekly figure.
- **South Korea's Hormuz deployment question (IND-20260928-2):** no Korean government statement found this week.
- **Iraq after the coalition mission (IND-20260930-2):** no attributed militia attack found yet; deadline October 14.
- **US carrier and amphibious deployment (IND-20261004-2):** arrival not yet reported; deadline October 25.

5. Revisions and Lessons

No material correction to `instructions/korea-exposure.md` was needed. Two lessons: quotes mislabelled as settles produced a wrong Brent narrative on October 10 (corrected in today's daily brief), so a quote should not be described as a move until a settle exists; and casualty counts at Riyadh airport came from different attacks and sources, so they should be reported by incident and not summed.